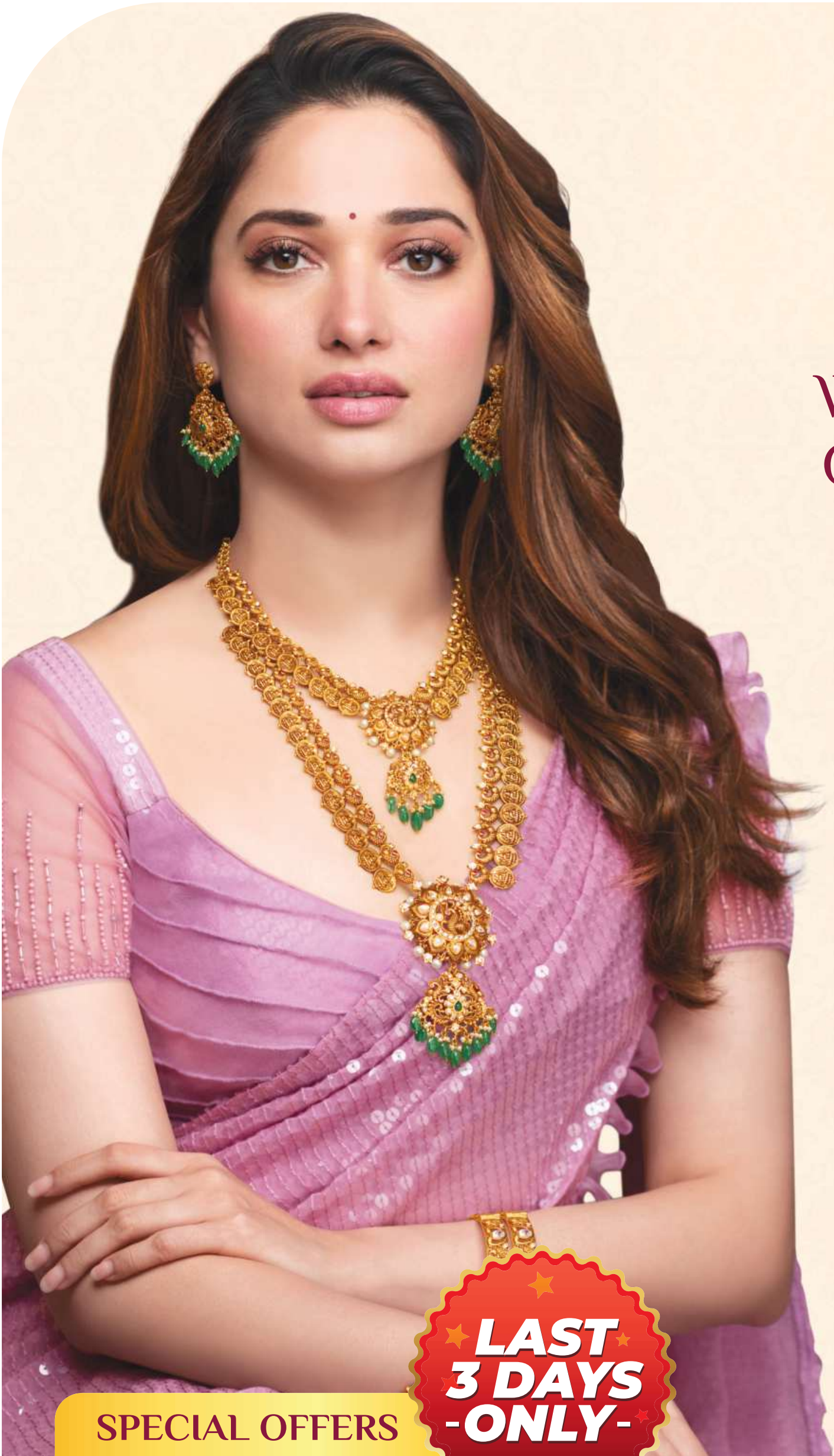




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Prime Video's upcoming series, *Matka King*, feels like a time capsule to another era. Set in the 1960s in a Mumbai that was transitioning quickly to a cosmopolitan city, the show highlights the period through a focus on gambling and its impact on common people. There is a surge of underdog energy in its frames as the protagonist, Brij Bhatti, starts his own gambling den with his own set of rules and innovations. He is portrayed without panache by Vijay Varma, who finds a sense of regularity in his being. With a touch of ambition in his personality coupled with an outlook of a middle-class hustler, Brij is the Mumbaikar for the ages. Honesty is his virtue, which also becomes his biggest selling point as he draws betted cards in front of the audience.

It was a difficult world for Varma to inhabit. "I didn't know any of the card tricks. So, I was constantly switching between playing with the cards and smoking a *beedi* while wearing an outfit that I am not familiar with. It took me some months to process all the information but I was ready when we began shooting finally," recalls Varma.

The challenge was also to portray the language of the times effectively. Varma feels that there is little room to improvise in such a case as there has been a considerable change in speaking styles since the 1960s. "You can't say 'take a chill pill' or 'vibe' or any of the words that are popular today. So, we had to be really careful. We were trying to find some words that were used in the 1960s, like *pyaare*, which belongs to that era," says Varma.

Directed by Nagraj Manjule (also co-creator and co-writer), known for helming acclaimed Marathi films like *Fandry* and *Sairat*, *Matka King* has long been in the making. Earlier, its co-producer Ashish Aryan was entrenched in the world of Matka gambling for 12-14 years and was trying to build something along with Manjule. However, it was only when co-creator and co-writer



Hitting the jackpot

Actor Vijay Varma, co-star Siddharth Jadhav and co-writer and co-creator Abhay Koranne discuss *Matka King*, and collaborating with Nagraj Manjule

Abhay Koranne came on board that the story progressed. "They couldn't quite crack a way into the narrative. So, I gave it a shot and wrote a story which Siddharth Roy Kapur (producer) liked," says Koranne, who later narrated the story to Nagraj in an "idyllic setting". "He was shooting for a film in a typical remote village with a lake, mountain and horse stable. It was the perfect location to narrate something. We sat and he loved the story I had written. That's how

things took off," Koranne says. Like a Nagraj Manjule narrative, the show carries a layering of the social life of characters, who are pushed to the limits due to raging inequalities. One among them, Dagdu, is a limping daily wage worker, who joins Brij in hope of a better life. Dagdu is portrayed with restraint by Siddharth Jadhav, a popular actor in Marathi cinema. He says that he was waiting to work with Nagraj. "Whenever I would meet him in award shows, I would

tell him to cast me for a role in his film. It didn't matter to me if it was a prominent role or not, I just wanted to be present in a film by Nagraj Popatrao Manjule. So, I was overjoyed when I received a call from him for *Matka King*," says Siddharth. Becuase of

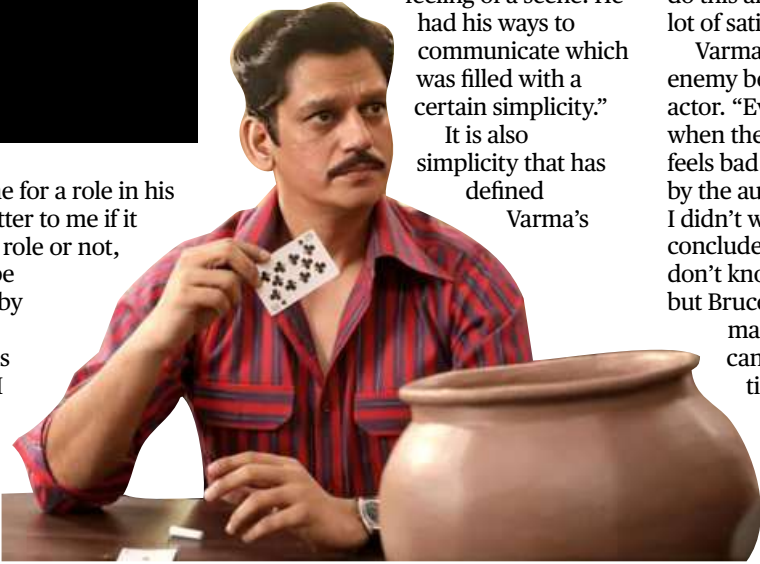
Stills from *Matka King*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



his admiration for Nagraj, Jadhav says that he was extra alert while working with him on set. "I was constantly asking him if I was doing everything the right way. And all he would say is, 'It is best'. Working with him gave me a new perspective. He would say that the character is nothing but me and that I should just react most organically to get a moment right. That really simplified everything," Jadhav says.

Varma seconds this as he adds, "He (Nagraj) is a man of few words. And he thinks in Marathi. So, there were times when some Marathi words would slip into his Hindi and then he would ask around for the translation. When it became harder, he would just narrate some lines of a poem to convey the feeling of a scene. He had his ways to communicate which was filled with a certain simplicity."

It is also simplicity that has defined Varma's



work ever since he made the mark playing a revolutionary in *Chittagong* (2012). That still wasn't the role that would make everyone notice him. Recognition came much later with an even smaller role in *Pink* (2016), where he appeared barely for a few minutes. What stayed along, however, was the ease with which he embodied a goon, not appearing to be a try-hard but just slipping gently into the skin of the character. A trace of that effortlessness is seen in all of his work since then. How does he manage to bring that authenticity?

Varma takes a pause before replying, "*Kuch nahi, bahut dino tak bhookha rehta hai na aadmi, to bade maze se khata hai* (When a man stays hungry for long, then he eats with joy). I was waiting for a long time to do this and now I just work with a lot of satisfaction."

Varma feels that 'effort' is like an enemy between the audience and actor. "Everyone can smell the effort when they see you on-screen and it feels bad when your effort is caught by the audience. That was one thing I didn't want to do," he says and concludes, quoting Bruce Lee, "I don't know if it's a real quote or AI, but Bruce Lee said that you can master 10,000 kicks or you can master one kick 10,000 times. While preparing for a role, I believe in doing one thing many times too."

Matka King will be released on Prime Video on April 17

Jalebi hopping in Jodhpur

Spend a weekend in the Blue City at an ancestral home-turned-boutique hotel, explore community craft initiatives, and eat your way through jalebis, gulab jamun sabzis and rabri ladoos

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A week before I landed in Jodhpur on a warm February morning, I was on a hunt for recommendations: of the best street food spots, sights to see, and bazaars to visit. I was not disappointed. Passionate members of a city-based 'thindi' WhatsApp group sent meticulously drafted Excel sheets and lists that almost tailor-made my itinerary.

Armed with these reccos, I arrived in Jodhpur on a warm Saturday afternoon all set to head to Chandelao, a village located an hour away, for the weekend. The car made its way through the village before I reached Chandelao Garh, an ancestral home transformed into a boutique heritage hotel by owner Praduman Singh. Here, I was first welcomed by the team's furry hosts Sheru and Pluto, and then Praduman's son Veer Singh and daughter-in-law Yashodhara Chauhan.

After serving as the ancestral home of the Kumpawat Rathores for centuries, Praduman opened the doors of Chandelao Garh to the world in 1997 (after a careful restoration in 1995) to offer guests an immersive experience of the region. The first guests, he says, was an adventurous Australian biker gang on a pan-India tour. The property has 21 rooms that were former 'mardana' (men's quarters), and stables.

A cobblestoned path lined with bougainvilleas



and jaal trees leads me to a 'courtyard' room that once housed the family's horses. Retaining the earthy charm of the original structure, the room features stone walls that hold old family portraits, a spacious bed, and a sitting area.

For guests, there is a range of experiences on offer. Choose a jeep safari to explore the countryside, a bird watching expedition to the Olvi Lake, a sunset safari and desert barbeque, a trip to Pipar Bazaar, and Mehrangarh Fort. My top picks? A dinner on the rooftop – where Veer made jangli maas (savoured by all non-vegetarians), and the meal ended with a delicious gajar ka halwa made by Yashodhara's grandmother – and a tour of Jodhpur led by Veer.

The latter includes a breakfast walk, and so, with my questionable photography skills and raging appetite, we arrived in Old City's sleeping streets at 7am to kickstart the day with piping hot, crisp, noodle-thin jalebis at Motu Jalebi, a family-run shop that has been around for over 50 years. We walk this off by visiting the stepwell,



ghantaghar (clock tower), and circle back for some delicious kachori panchkutta (a traditional Rajasthani vegetable made with ker, sangri, kumatia, gunda, and amchur) at Solanki Mishtaan Bhandar. We quickly washed this down with tea, and breakfast continued to include khatta-meetha samosas at Shahi Samosa, and mirchi bada at Surya Namkeen. Unlike chaat streets in other cities, there are no chutneys offered anywhere. "You eat the snacks as-is to get their flavour," a shopkeeper tells me.

We then headed to Mehrangarh Fort (pro tip: opt for the audio guide), a stunning hilltop fortress that is now maintained by the Mehrangarh Museum Trust. For lunch, we paused at Shandar

Sweet Home to savour a traditional Jodhpuri lunch: gulab jamun sabzi, rasmalai sabzi, a Kabuli pulao with fruits and cashews, flake (papad), and dahi bada with vadas dunked in thick, creamy sweet curd and cut fruits. And no, we were still not done. Braving the now bustling streets of Old City, we ended the tour with melt-in-your-mouth rabri ladoos, rabri ghehar, and mava kachoris at Mohanji Mithaiwala.

The day ended with a traditional Rajasthani dinner of ker sangri and parathas, and a barbeque, overlooking the arid Thar Desert. With full hearts and abigger belly, I was glad to fly home with everything on that borrowed Excel sheet ticked off.

The writer was in Jodhpur at the invitation of Chandelao Garh



(Clockwise from below) Street food in Jodhpur; and snapshots of Chandelao Garh. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



INDIA STORY
Now on the TIME100 list, Chef Vikas Khanna talks about Bungalow in New York, and leading with restraint **P6**

metro PLUS THE  **HINDU**



(Clockwise from above) Stills from *Krantijyoti Vidyalaya*; *Sabar Bonda*; *Ata Thambaycha Naayi*; *Aatmapamphlet*; *Dashavatar*; *Tighee*; and (below) a still from *Vaalvi*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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A young man living in Bombay at the peak of colonial rule is determined to make a film. His journey is brought to life by director Paresh Mokashi in his Marathi debut feature, *Harishchandrachi Factory*. The young man, Dadasaheb Phalke – who would go on to produce over 90 films and 25 shorts – represents the spirit of the indie filmmaker: hustling, failing, and learning on the go.

Fresh, bold, Marathi

In a state dominated by big-budget Hindi films and Bollywood stars, Marathi cinema is carving out space with fresher, more rooted stories — increasingly finding younger audiences on OTT platforms. A guide to discovering them

Beyond theatres
For Marathi cinema, his legacy carries particular weight in a city long dominated by Bollywood’s scale and glamour. That, however, is beginning to change as viewers around the country and world, are now discovering these films thanks to social media, subtitles and OTT platforms, and getting hooked to their grounded, lived-in stories.

In the last decade, *Fandry* (2013), *Sairat* (2016) and *Court* (2014) became unexpected breakout hits, leading audiences to discover lesser known movies like *Nude* (2018), *Shwaas* (2004), *Vihir* (2009) and *Kaasav* (2017).

Of late, a string of young filmmakers is exploring a wider range of subjects. The quirky, heartwarming *Jhimma* (2021) and *Jhimma 2* (2023) by Hemant Dhome, for example, which tell crackling stories of a group of women rediscovering their independence during a trip to London.

Stories that reflect everyday lives
While making *Jhimma*, Hemant says that he wanted to address women in the audience, particularly home-makers. “A lot of men are fixated on cricket and OTT while younger people are hooked to their phones. Home-makers are looking for occasions to step out of their house for get-togethers. I wanted to tap into this emotion,” says Hemant as he gears up for the third part in the franchise.

Jhimma 2 was backed by Aanand L Rai, who says he finds a “disarming honesty” in Marathi cinema.

The filmmaker, known for directing Hindi romantic-dramas like, *Raanjhanaa* and *Atrangi Re*, has also produced other Marathi films, including the family-drama *Fussclass Dabhade* and National Award-winner Ashish Bende’s *Aatmapamphlet*, which told an endearing story of a group of kids coming to terms with their identity in society.

“While working with these directors, there was no confusion or

overthinking, just a strong emotional core driving everything. You see that honesty across the range of stories being told today, from intimate, women-led narratives to films drawing from folklore. That kind of heart is rare in cinema, and being part of that process takes you back to why you started telling stories in the first place,” Aanand says.

An industry built on theatre
Actor Subodh Bhawe, who participated in inter-collegiate play competitions, says “Even though cinema and theatre are different mediums, the approach of studying a character remains the same. So, the majority of Marathi film actors have been doing theatre from a young age as there is a tradition of watching and acting in plays in Maharashtra. All of that helps in easing the process of thinking like the characters we play.” He been part of diverse stories like *Katyar Kaljat Ghusali* (2015), *Lokmanya* (2015) and *Vaalvi* (2023).

Senior actor Sachin Khedekar, who has worked in movies across languages, says that the honesty in their performances is also due to the lack of a star system in Marathi cinema, unlike Bollywood. “Marathi audiences come to the cinemas to see work that defines their language, drama culture and literary values. Actors try to be real in their performances because anything over-the-top will be rejected by the people,” he says.

Struggle for visibility
Despite these varied offerings, Marathi films have traditionally been

sidelined by Bollywood and Hollywood releases. Devoid of powerful PR machinery, most Marathi films often go largely unnoticed.

Now, they are being promoted in the most organic, and possibly powerful way: word of mouth, as seen recently in *Tighee*, which is still running after a month in theatres.

Actor Jitendra Joshi acknowledges the impact created by *Tighee*, but also questions the low-turn out for experimental films like *Ghaat*, *Sabar Bonda* and *Gondhal*. “There are filmmakers who are trying new stuff and producers are backing them too. It is important to go out and watch films made by new directors, starring new actors with new voices,” says Jitendra.

Subodh adds that the reason for low-audience turnout is also due to

cinema not being as entrenched in the culture of Maharashtra as theatre. “Even though the earliest Indian film was made by a Marathi-speaking Dadasaheb Phalke, Marathi cinema doesn’t get as much support in the State,” he says, reflecting on the competition faced by Marathi films with Bollywood. “The comparison is a bit skewed as a Marathi film is made with a budget of ₹1-2 crore and a Hindi film is made with ₹100-150 crore,” he says.

Sachin adds, “It is a small-size industry and we make good films but we lack the ability to release them well. There is a need to improve budgets, we need to also increase the percentage of successful films.”

The bright side on OTT
The visibility remains fairly good on OTT, where smaller films have been

Five Marathi films to check out

- **Muramba** (2017): A romantic-drama about a boy, who breaks up with his girlfriend as his parents try convincing them to get back together.
- **Mi Vasantrao Deshpande** (2022): An immersive biopic about a genius classical singer that raises larger questions about the relevance of art.
- **Zombivali** (2022): A rare Marathi Zombie comedy that blends social commentary firmly within its entertaining layers.
- **Dashavtar** (2025): An ageing folk theatre performer uses his traditional wisdom to protect his village from the clutches of a mining project.
- **April May 99** (2025): A charming, nostalgic story of three friends in a coastal town, whose summer vacation gets exciting with the arrival of a sweet girl.

discovered by an audience across the country. *The Disciple*, Chaitanya Tamhane’s much-awaited sophomore feature after *Court* found a release on Netflix in 2020 and was discussed avidly on social media for its inventive filmmaking and refreshing themes.

More recently, off-beat films like *Vaalvi* and *Aatmapamphlet* found a new audience with its availability on ZEE5. The streaming platform has also been backing Marathi shows, with last year’s *Baai Tujhyapai*, directed by Nipun Dharmadhikari,

creating thoughtful conversation around menstruation and the recently released, *Hey Kaay Navin!* by Varun Narvekar leading a feel-good romantic-drama with charm.

Hema VR, Business head, Marathi ZEE5, says that they have seen strong engagement with content across local languages with Marathi being the “second most-watched language on the platform”. “It reinforces our belief that audiences increasingly gravitate towards stories told in their own language. Marathi in particular, is a very evolved market with a strong cultural identity and a deep appreciation for both rooted and experimental narratives,” she said.

The streamer currently has a more than 20 Marathi web-series across different genres and aims to expand the slate further. “Our approach going forward is to scale both volume and variety, increasing the number of originals, alongside sharpening the storytelling and collaborating with strong local creators who understand the pulse of the audience,” said Hema.

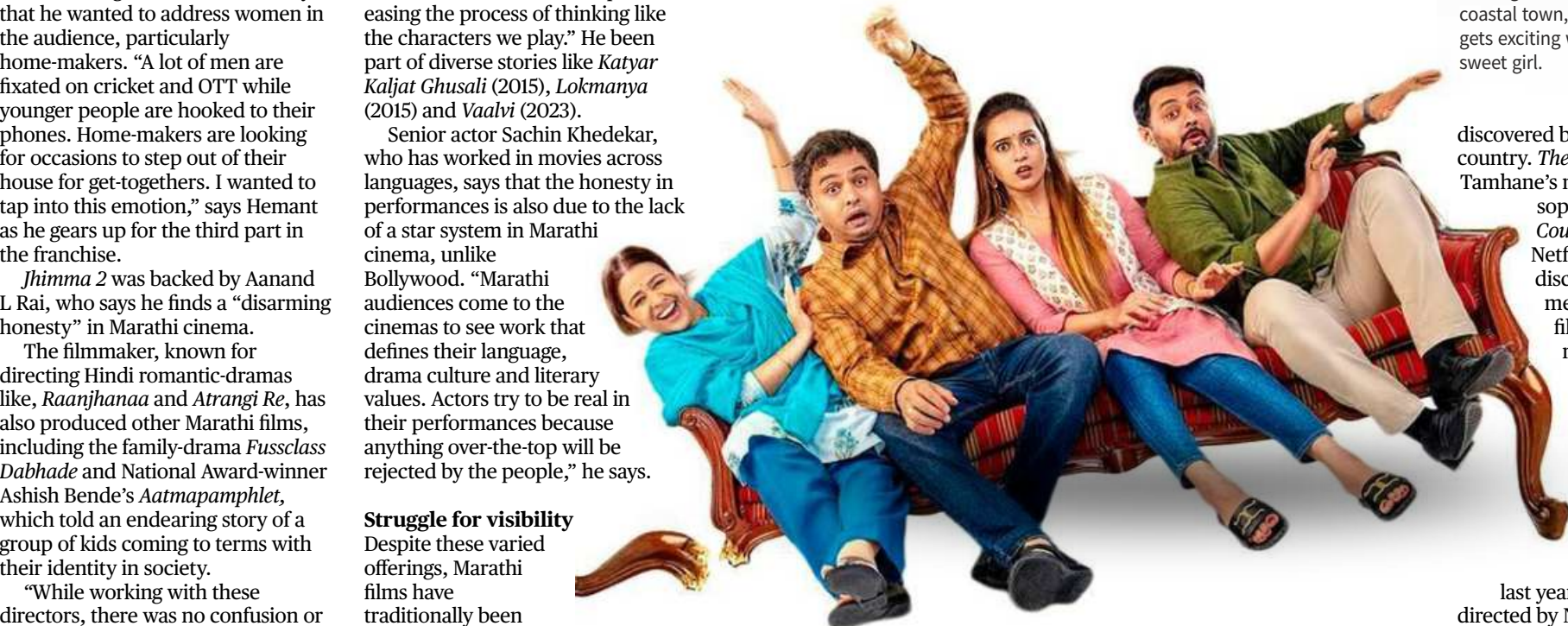
On the other hand, actor and content creator Sarang Sathaye has been giving space to independent Marathi films on the YouTube channel of ‘BhaDiPa’, where every month more than thousand people are watching them through membership. “Out of these, even if 500 people go to watch a Marathi film on the first day, it will make a difference. There should be more such film clubs across the State which will help in creating a culture and eventually facilitate business to distributors,” he says.

A shift underway
Things are beginning to change. 2026 began on a joyful note for Marathi cinema as Hemant’s *Krantijyoti Vidyalaya* became a sleeper hit.

An inspiring glimpse of this storytelling and its impact was seen in last year’s feel-good social drama *Ata Thambaycha Naayi*, directed by debutant Shivraj Waichal. The film was about a group of sanitation workers studying to pass their class X examinations. It quickly found resonance with audiences for its sensitive portrayal of the workers and powerful performances by the actors.

Apart from ending the dry spell for Marathi films at the box office, the comedy-drama also created a real-world impact.

Shivraj says. “The municipality organised screenings of the film for its workers. Many of them were so inspired after watching it that they too began to study, and then took their Xth board exams.”



pick of the week



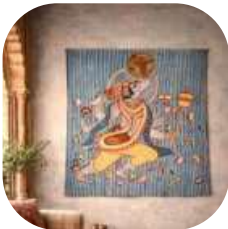
Bite into summer

This summer, look beyond mangoes. The Backyard is hosting a summer brunch workshop, putting the spotlight on seasonal produce. Hosted by Dough Dough Deli the brunch invites participants to explore recipes using locally sourced produce like ice apple, watermelon, moringa leaves and kokum. Some dishes will be pre-made, while others will be assembled. On May 3, from 11am to 1am at Backyard, Adyar. Entry ₹1,600. Register at [beacons.ai](#)



Time to quiz

Think you know your cricket better than your crew? Time to prove it. With the T20 buzz in full swing, quizmaster Arjun Mohan is hosting a lively quiz night packed with tricky questions, banter, and bragging rights. So polish your T20 trivia knowledge, bring your squad, enjoy good food and drinks, and battle it out for the top spot. April 18 from 7.30 pm onwards *The Spotted Deer at The Palomar, Sholinganallur*. Entry is free.



Heritage in hand

Anvaya, presented by Aabharnam Foundation, showcases India's historic craft, art and textile traditions through contemporary interpretations. Curated by Neha Verma, it brings together 18 master artisans skilled in different forms like pattachitra, pichwai, kalamkari, kantha, alongside Benarasi and Chanderi weaves. Priced ₹1000 onwards. April 28 to 30 from 11am to 8pm at *The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah*.



Loomed legacy

City-based sari label House of Tuhil is all set to exhibit Meenakshi, a specially commissioned Kanchipuram silk sari. Inspired by goddess Madurai Meenakshi, it was earlier showcased at San Francisco's Asian Art Museum. A talk by musician-researcher S Jayakumar will precede the showcase, highlighting the textile's technique and links to South Indian heritage. On April 19, from 5.30pm onwards at *House of Tuhil, Adyar*.



THE NAKED TRUTH

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For a long time, the idea of dating after the age of 50 in India was acknowledged in theory but rarely in practice. You were expected to have completed that chapter already. To want romance again, or even companionship, could feel like reopening something that had been very carefully filed away and labelled “done.” What’s changed is not that people have suddenly become more romantic, but that they have become less interested in pretending they aren’t. Dating, at this stage, is approached with the same practical curiosity one might reserve for a new gym membership, or a WhatsApp group one didn’t entirely want to be added to, but will give a chance anyway. A senior editor in Mumbai, divorced for over a decade, described this recalibration with a clarity that felt less like a philosophy and more like a survival tactic. “I don’t have the stamina for confusion anymore,”

Golden age to date
New surveys and real stories reveal a shift toward companionship, discretion and low-drama relationships among older singles

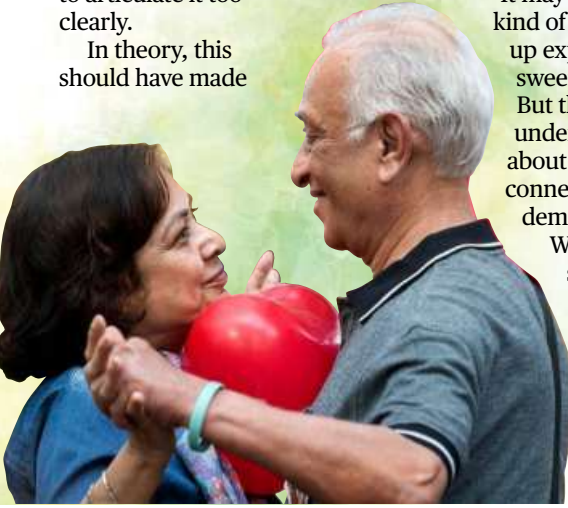
she said. “If I have to sit and decode what someone meant, I’m already tired.” She started dating again on terms that were once been described as unromantic but now feel almost aspirational in their restraint. “I’m not lonely,” she said. “So if I’m choosing to spend time with you, it has to feel better than being on my own.” There is someone she meets now, occasionally, without the need to define or categorise it. “It works because it fits,” she explained. “Not because it completes anything.”

Ground reality
If you step outside metro cities, the situation becomes

both, clearer and slightly amusing. A survey by dating app QuackQuack in 2023 found that a significant number of men between 50 and 65 in Tier 2 cities described online dating as their “salvation”, which is a wonderfully dramatic word for what is, in essence, exchanging polite messages with a stranger and occasionally meeting them for coffee. In the same survey, around 27% of women over 50 said they prioritise companionship over romantic love, which sounds understated until you realise it is actually quite exacting. But outside of metros, trying to date can feel almost theoretical, which is where the gap becomes most visible. For many in Tier 2 cities, the idea of attending a singles mixer is an option that doesn’t exist. Even in cities where these spaces do exist, they still feel like something you have to actively seek out. A friend’s aunt in Mumbai, recently single after a divorce, found herself doing exactly that, going slightly out of her way to attend a mixer called Let’s Socialise Offline, which she had discovered on Instagram. The event had already made its way through Gurgaon and Hyderabad in late March, followed by Pune and Bengaluru in early April. On paper, it offered exactly what feels missing from this entire conversation, a room full of people in similar circumstances, all presumably there for the same reason, even if no one was particularly keen to articulate it too clearly. In theory, this should have made

things easier. In practice, it required a surprising amount of collective nerve. “It was actually nice, just to see how many people showed up,” she said. “You don’t realise how many of us are out there until you’re all in the same room.” Conversations happened, but they rarely gathered momentum. “Few people exchanged numbers,” she said, in a tone that suggested this was less surprising than it might sound. “It’s not that people didn’t want to meet someone. It’s just that no one really knew how to behave once they were there.” The events themselves are infrequent, which only adds to the sense of tentative experimentation. “You don’t know when the next one will happen. I wish there were more of these.” A business owner in his early 50s in Delhi, who has never been married, described his experience with a kind of weary candour. “I’ve had a lot of almosts,” he said. “Enough to know what doesn’t work and what does.” He continues to date, though with a noticeable pause where there might once have been enthusiasm. “I like my life as it is,” he admitted. “But I also feel like there’s a part of it that hasn’t happened yet.” As for simplicity, that much-advertised ideal, he was unconvinced. “People say they want something simple,” he said. “But simple is actually very hard.” What emerges from all of this is a small shift in tolerance. It may not resemble the kind of love story one grows up expecting. There are no sweeping gestures here. But there is something undeniably appealing about it. A version of connection that only demands consideration. Which, at this stage, seems not only reasonable, but oddly romantic in its own right.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Clockwise from below) Butwal is considered the gateway to Lumbini, the birthplace of Gautama Buddha, Maya Devi Mandir, Zing Bar at Hyatt Place, Chef Umesh Tamang, Sadeko bhatmas — a crunchy soyabean salad, and bartender Hari. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



portions of rum, whisky and brandy. His top suggestions are the Golden Wash, a ghee-washed whisky cocktail, and Ayurvedic Rum, made with spiced Khukri rum infused with Chyavanprash. Butwal’s unpredictable weather tests your patience and rewards perseverance.

In between, a visit to the rain-washed Maya Devi Mandir, an ancient Buddhist shrine situated at the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Lumbini, and World Peace Pagoda, helps contextualise Nepal’s historical, cultural and spiritual arc. While the day gently slips into the dusk, an aromatic massage at the spa soothes the tired nerves. Deepa, at the spa counter, offers the menu and three bottles of oils. The spa area, with four rooms, including one for the couple massage, is earthy yet chic. The massage is followed by steam, bath and sauna – particularly in that same order.

For the nocturnal, Nepal’s casinos offer more than just luck-testing arenas! It is interesting to note that Nepal’s Casino Regulations prohibit Nepalese citizens from entering a casino or gambling there. Though legal, casinos are only strictly allowed as a tourism activity for foreigners. In Butwal, Casino Tiger Palace is the biggest. It accepts Indian rupees and charges a customary entry fee of nearly ₹2,000, which includes a lifetime membership of the casino and allows two free games. Somewhere between the land and sky, amidst green hills adorned by the adventurous-green Tinau River, the fate of Nepal’s impending elections stands discussed. A co-passenger predicts: “It has to be the rapper-turned-politician Belan (Balendra Shah) of Kathmandu. He will win”.

By the time news filters through that Balen has won, Butwal seems unchanged – still unhurried, still understated. Somewhere between a trading town and the pilgrimage gateway, between hills and plains, it remains what it has always been: Nepal’s quiet in-between destination.

The writer was in Nepal at the invitation of Hyatt Place Butwal.

Terai it out!

On the road to Lumbini, Butwal offers more than a stopover, drawing travellers into the Terai’s food traditions, everyday life, and slower, less-travelled routes

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Somewhere between the overlooked and the underrated lies Butwal, a city in western Nepal that rarely figures on tourist itineraries. Cradled by the Siwalik Hills, known locally as Chure Pahad, it stands at the edge of Nepal’s Terai (plains) region, with the Tinau River winding quietly through. Part trading hub, part cultural centre, this quaint valley town – 26 kilometres from the India-Nepal border and 123 kilometres from Gorakhpur Airport – serves as a gateway to Lumbini, birthplace of Gautama Buddha, and offers a scenic intersection of hills and plains. From a suite at the newly-opened Hyatt Place Butwal, the landscape unfolds in layers: grey-blue hills rising beyond

clusters of colourful houses, each crowned with a mumty (a small structure built on a rooftop) and threaded by serpentine lanes. “Butwal’s proximity to India, particularly the Gorakhpur feeder market in Uttar Pradesh, positions it as a natural hospitality gateway for cross-border business and leisure travel. The seamless road connectivity from Gorakhpur and Gautam Buddha International Airport reinforce its tourism and business potential,” says Tushar Nagar, pre-opening general manager at Hyatt, explaining Butwal’s scope in Hyatt Hotels Corporation’s strategic growth across South Asia. The hotel was up and running in December last year, he adds. The conversation meanders from some of the most-visited sites in and around Butwal – Jitgadi Fort, Siddhartha Cable Car,



Manimukanda Park, Akhileshwor Mahadeva Temple and Nuwakot Hill – and halts at food. Head chef Umesh Tamang, unassuming and reverently passionate, paces to the table from behind Zing Bar’s kitchen door.

Rubbing his hands together, as if warming up for a challenge, he smiles and introduces the topographic disposition of Nepal before placing the menu card. “Nepal has many cuisines; the spectrum ranges from the ceremonial richness of Newari food to the nourishing simplicity of Himalayan dishes. The tharu cuisine of the Terai region is closely connected to Nature and rivers, with dishes like dhikri (steamed rice flour dumplings); ghonghi (snail curry); anadi rice dishes (sticky rice specialty); tarua (lightly spiced vegetable fritters) and tharu style fish curry. Since we are in the Terai, try some mutton with local rice and small bites?” he suggests, before disappearing into his kitchen.

To the Indian palate, the taste is favourable, echoing familiar impressions of spices and flavours in home kitchens. Umesh’s description of Nepal’s traditional dishes lingers. It evokes sensorial graphics of dishes like thukpa (noodle soup) and thenthuk (hand-pulled noodle soup) from the Himal (mountains) region; and wachipa (rice mixed with burnt chicken feather powder and spices), kinema curry (made with fermented soybean), sargemba (mixed meat and radish curry), tongba (fermented millet drink) from Rai cuisine (eastern hills). With a full stomach and a mind still turning over Nepal’s culinary details, the luxury of a siesta beckons – there is plenty to dream about. The reverie is interrupted, however, by a timely knock from room service, a reminder for a spa session followed by drinks at the hotel bar. Behind the counter, Hari, the bartender, juggles the bottles with practised ease, assembling heady potions with generous



Beyond lip service

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Blame it on India's diverse topography and its rich spectrum of skin tones, finding a make-up brand that truly works can feel like a challenge.

It was this very challenge that got Priya George Lakshman thinking. "I would wear these products while on a trip and all would be fine, but once I got here, I realised how it melted, it started feeling heavy," she says. That is when she began working on her brand, Svam Beauty, which she describes as high-performance make-up that works in real Indian conditions.

At the launch of the brand, Priya's dance teacher, kathak exponent Jigyasa Giri shares an interesting anecdote; about how Priya chose to also examine how dance make-up has been used over the years, and the need to come up with alternatives.

"While we traditionally wear a 'pancake' base on stage which is the only product that we thought can withstand how much we sweat onstage as well as look good to a large audience, Priya suggested we experiment with the makeup she was developing; from foundation, blush, primer, lip crayons and liners. We went through several

Inspired by the demands of dance make-up, Svam beauty focuses on formulations that suit Indian skin and withstand heat, sweat, and long wear

experiments and figured out the sequencing. For the last few shows, most of our base make-up has been from Svam beauty," she says, adding how important it is for dancers to feel comfortable with make-up onstage.

For Priya as well, dance has played an important role in her make-up journey and how it led to her first tryst with make-up as a child. "I firmly believe as an artist, make-up is like art. It always feels like working on a painting...something that always excites me to work on," she says. Priya says that the make-up has

been developed and tested over the last three years.

"Despite being such a fast-growing beauty market, many of us have had to compromise with make-up that doesn't suit our skin tones, having to mix and match to arrive at perfect shades, or simply using formulations that were created based on western trends. As an Indian brand, I first take into consideration our realities and then work on what works for us best. Every shade is calibrated for us," she explains.

For Svam, Priya has worked with formulators in Europe and South



▲ Svam Beauty's first launches are the lip crayons and lip liners, with more products expected to release in the coming months. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Korea, and she says at factories, which manufacture for a host of global make-up giants.

Trial run
I give their first launches, the Svam All Day Definition Comfort Matte Lip Crayon, and the Svam All Day Definition Comfort Matte Lip Liner (with vitamin C, peptides and hyaluronic filling spheres,

manufactured in Germany), a spin.

There are 10 shades (with names like Born To Lead, Game Changer, and more) that are a mix of both dark and light colours which suit a range of skin tones. I pick Fearless and Free, described as a sunlight clay brown shade, best suited for those who prefer a dark lippie for daily wear. On first application, the crayon, worn without a layer of lip balm, glides smoothly, and takes a couple of minutes to dry. The product is fragrance-free, and despite being a matte crayon, does not feel as drying. The the colour stays on for a good four hours, and remains transfer and smudge proof. While I choose to do a touch up after lunch, there is still quite a bit of product left on my lips, which makes it long-lasting.

Priya says that Svam, which is vegan, dermatologically-tested and cruelty-free, has been developed in line with EU cosmetic standards and aligns itself with the Sephora Clean Ingredients guidelines. "I am

taking this a step forward and have conceived our own quality assurance as well – the SVAM Intelligent Clean™ framework. For instance, while the Sephora guidelines allow for a bit of fragrance, I have completely taken it off our products to make it more accessible for those with sensitive, irritation-prone skin," she explains.

Over the next few months and into the coming year, Svam is set to expand its line-up with a range of new launches, including foundation, skin tints, kajal, highlighter, and blush. While her early launches, the crayons and lip liners are available only on the Svam website, Priya is looking at a presence on beauty e-commerce retailers like Nykaa and Tira in the future as well.

Inspired by her tryst with stage make-up, which is designed to endure heat, sweat, and stage lights, Svam endeavors to create everyday products that work just as hard.

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Shalbha Sarda

Miss Peahlo was dressed in khaki, sitting across from me at the Sitatunga Great Plains Private Island Camp. Between us was a generous, carefully plated meal, but she ate cautiously, as if such abundance required permission. I asked her what her name meant. “It means pain and rejection in Setswana,” she said matter-of-factly. “My father left my mother before I was born.”

She prefers to be called Miss P. She is a mother to a six-year-old daughter and, like her own mother, is raising her child on her own. The meaning of her name, she says, will not be passed on to her daughter.

Sitatunga Private Island lies on a rare stretch of land in the Okavango Delta in northern Botswana. This part of the planet is known for its one-of-a-kind landscapes created by the world’s largest inland delta. It is a UNESCO World Heritage Site recognised for its biodiversity and ancient cultures.

Miss P comes from the Bambukushu tribe. Her ancestors were believed to be the rainmakers of the Okavango. Today, these people are struggling to survive in the modern world. In the Okavango Delta, work is scarce and largely limited to remote luxury safari camps. For women like Miss P, the barriers are even higher. Restricted access to education and deep-rooted gender inequality keep many out of the formal economy.



At a remote safari camp, women like Miss P are protecting endangered wildlife, supporting families, and quietly transforming gender roles in one of Africa’s most fragile ecosystems

When women guard the wild



(Clockwise from left) Miss P comes from the Bambukushu tribe; and female rangers at Okavango. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

But jobs are not the only thing lost in this landscape. For perspective, at the turn of the 20th Century, the global rhinoceros population was estimated at 3,00,000 to 4,00,000. In the latter years of that century, only about 2,000 remained worldwide. Around the same time, Botswana lost its last rhinoceros. It was shot in 1985.

This was the inheritance from which the Great Plains Foundation began its work. The Foundation is the non-profit arm of Great Plains Conservation, a tourism company focussed on ethical and sustainable wildlife tourism. It was established in

2006 by Dereck and Beverly Joubert. The duo, National Geographic Explorers, has spent more than four decades documenting and protecting wilderness in Kenya, Zimbabwe, and Botswana. Today, Great Plains Conservation operates 20 camps across these three countries. Hope for women of ancient cultures and for endangered wildlife found a common thread in one of the foundation’s initiatives, the Female Ranger Programme. In 2017, an accident left Beverly Joubert hospitalised in the Okavango Delta for an extended period; she grew close to the women who cared for her.

“Though their lives were vastly different, their stories reflected the same patterns of limited opportunity, economic dependence, and vulnerability. I wanted to do something for them,” Dereck says.

Joubert explains that one female ranger’s salary can sustain up to 10 family members. Women also proved more effective than men at reducing human-wildlife conflict, drawing on their deep ties to communities and maternal instincts.

In 2022, when Great Plains advertised 24 ranger positions for women in Botswana and Zimbabwe, more than 200 applications arrived within a single day. Those selected entered a demanding six-month training programme. By the end of the programme the rangers, like Irene Kamwengo, were equipped with skills they did not think were within their grasp. “I am proud to be a female ranger because having this opportunity has given me many opportunities to learn a lot of things which I did not know or never had, such as having a driving licence, learning more about Nature, in which I did a Nature guiding course, boat training course, first aid course, and

photography course,” she says. It takes \$15,000 to cover the cost of one ranger’s salary and training. “The salary is better than most jobs available to women here,” Miss P says. “Accommodation and food are covered, so most of what I earn goes to my family. For me, it means getting my daughter into a good school.”

Today, Great Plains remains the only tourism-based company in Africa running a Female Ranger Programme.

Rangers like Miss P now spend their days collecting data and educating communities across the delta. Recently, she and her team have been tracking reintroduced rhinoceroses in the Duba Plains Camp. “We have to track and count each one every single day to make sure they are okay. As a mother myself, I understand how the rhinos’ behavioural patterns change during pregnancy and after birth.” Rumbidzai Musembwa, who is currently pursuing her Master’s degree, says, “I also love the interdisciplinary nature of conservation science, where I get to work with ecologists, local communities, and policymakers to create solutions that benefit both people and the planet.”

But for women, the job comes with its own challenges, especially during their menstrual cycles, when they are sleeping in open forests with a lack of bathrooms. “We never show our male counterparts that we cannot handle this. We try to stay brave”, Miss P. Her being brave has helped in other ways. During a routine boat patrol, Miss P was aboard with two Botswana Defence Force officers and another ranger. She was the only woman. On the return journey, the boat operator suddenly lost consciousness. Miss P was the only person capable of manoeuvring the vessel through hippo-filled waters. As she took control, a hippo charged the boat, forcing water into it and causing it to sink. She used her training in swimming and boat manoeuvring to save three other lives.

Back home, Miss P is involved in a children’s camp project, a role she took on because she knows how to drive. “It is not every day that these children get to see a woman behind the wheel of a Land Cruiser. When a girl came and asked me how to get the uniform and the vehicle, I felt that I had done my job.”

(Clockwise from right) Rhino sighting at Pobitora; The Assamese thali; interiors by Naga designer Aku Zeliang; View of the cottages at Rhino & River Wildlife Retreat and Spa in Assam’s Mayong. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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A trip to Assam feels incomplete without catching a glimpse of the one-horned rhinoceros and soaking in the grandeur of the Brahmaputra. For a relaxed itinerary that delivers both, Rhino & River Wildlife Retreat and Spa offers a neat solution. Located at Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary in Mayong, the resort overlooks the Brahmaputra, bringing wildlife and riverine beauty together in one stay.

Step onto your balcony in the morning and the river glistens in the sun; as for the rhino, sightings are almost guaranteed, though thankfully, not at your door.

About 75 kilometres from Guwahati airport, the retreat offers a first-hand experience of Assam’s slow, rural rhythm. No matter the season, mornings begin with birdsong on the balcony. Mynahs, hornbills, pied and white-throated kingfishers, and sparrows keep the air lively, while the riverbank gradually stirs as boats ferry passengers across the water.

Designed as a boutique wilderness property, Rhino & River



expresses luxury through restraint. The resort has 16 log-hut cottages, each conceived as a private sanctuary. Using natural, locally sourced materials, the architecture – developed in collaboration with Naga designer Aku Zeliang – draws from traditional Assamese monsoon houses and bamboo craftsmanship. Interiors feature bamboo and wood construction, handmade textiles and tribal art, celebrating the craft heritage of Northeast India.

Breakfast, served as Assamese *jalpaan* at Ban Kahi – the poolside signature restaurant – includes *pani pitha*, *sira-doi*, and *luci* with *alu torkari*, a comforting, runny potato curry.

A stay at Rhino & River Wildlife Retreat and Spa blends wildlife safaris, river cruises and Assamese hospitality

Where rhinos roam free



River’s resident naturalist, Amarjyoti Boro, brings an intimate knowledge of Pobitora’s biodiversity to every experience.

Taking it slow, I began with a walk through the village to the marketplace. Thatched homes with mud-polished floors line the way; gardens grow chillies without any gardener’s order, letting seasonal flowers and vegetables co-exist freely. The only constant sound is the rhythmic *khat-khat-khat* of hooooms at work. Most of these hooooms had *gamusa* (traditional Assamese towel) and *sadors* (part of everyday traditional dress for women).

Dropping into a home unannounced does not feel intrusive here. In true Assamese hospitality, I was offered a seat and refreshments without hesitation.

The retreat offers curated experiences ranging from treks and river cruises to jungle safaris and visits to Mayong town.

The experiences

I chose to immerse myself in local life – a safari at Pobitora to spot the famed one-horned rhino, and a river cruise in search of dolphins. Rhino &

The walk offers a lesson in how Assamese villages move to a rhythm of their own. At the *bozar* (market), duck eggs, fresh produce and bakery goods sit side by side.

Next came the safari into Pobitora. Accompanied by a naturalist, the jeep ride becomes as much about learning as spotting wildlife. Black-necked storks, black-winged stilts, green-winged teals, Asian open-bill storks, and bank swallows were among the birds we identified. Soon enough, a group of one-horned rhinos appeared, grazing calmly. Watching one from about 40-feet away, hearing it chomping grass in the stillness of the sanctuary, is humbling.

After a much-needed spa session, I headed out for the river cruise. The motorboat – locally called a *bhut-bhuti* – cuts through the Brahmaputra as a sharp breeze sweeps across the water. We were looking for the river dolphin

navigating against the strong current. “They’re usually spotted where the sand bed isn’t too high,” Amarjyoti explains. “The river carries silt, so shallow areas keep changing. Dolphins prefer spots with higher silt accumulation, not deep waters.”

We waited patiently before the first sighting. Spotting a river dolphin demands alertness. “They’re shy and very fast,” he adds.

This is also a moment to sit atop the boat with a cup of evening tea, watching the sun dip and children play along the riverbank.

Dining in

Food at Ban Kahi follows a farm-to-table approach. The table d’hôte, five-course Assamese menu is curated by Chef Kashmiri Nath, an advocate of regional cuisine, alongside Indian, Pan-Asian and western options. The resort’s culinary programme is led by Chef Ashish Rana.

One pleasant revelation is the Assamese love for pickles. The spread includes chilli, elephant apple, hog plum, Indian gooseberry, Indian olive and more.

That enthusiasm carries through to the traditional Assamese thali: *pitikas* (mashes), *khar*, fresh chutney, fish fry, vegetable fry, a vegetable curry, non-vegetarian curries, and *matir mahor dal* with *ou tenga* (black urad with elephant apple), a regional staple. Guests can also opt for à la carte dishes or Asian and North Indian fare; the menu is designed to accommodate varied preferences.

Dining here is accompanied not by recorded music, but by local artists playing indigenous instruments such as the *dhotora*, *taal* and bamboo flute, lending the meal a distinctly local rhythm.

And just when you think it is time to turn in, the clear night sky urges you to pause – inviting you to lie back and trace constellations before the day quietly fades.

The writer was in Assam at the invitation of Rhino & River Wildlife Retreat and Spa

(Clockwise from right) A tangaliya sari, a weaver at his loom, Jahabhai with his new collection of saris; a model in a tangaliya garment created for Jaypore. PRIYADARSHINI PAITANDY AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Jahabhai Laxmanbhai Rathod is certain he will not lose his job to a machine. “My work is handmade and it will continue to be done that way,” says Jahabhai, who has been creating tangaliya weaves for 48 years. Made on looms, the craft is known for its trademark dots or *danas* which form patterns that range from peacock and *navagraha* to the more modern deer and flowers. Earlier, it was typically done on cotton and wool, with handmade yarn made from sheep’s wool. Now mill-made yarn is used. And the fabric extends to silk, khadi, eri silk and kala cotton.

“I was 15 when I started working with tangaliya. My father, his father and ancestors have been doing this for more than 700 years. My 32-year-old son Baldev has now joined in,” says the 63-year-old.

I am in Surendranagar district in Gujarat, known for its tangaliya weaves, with the Jaypore team, to learn more about the craft, which is primarily practised by the Dangasiya community. We visit the village of Vastadi first. Narrow alleys dotted with cows lead us to Jahabhai’s house.

An artisanal lifestyle brand, Jaypore works with Jahabhai and his weavers for tangaliya woven kurtas and pants that are retailed out of its stores and website. For the forthcoming season the brand is exploring tangaliya saris, as part of its ongoing effort to expand the craft into new product categories. Manu Gupta, vice president and brand head, Jaypore, says the brand placed its first order with this weaving community in 2025, commissioning 100-plus pieces. He adds that it is important to them that the narrative around tangaliya also highlights the people, traditions, and cultural legacy that sustain it.

Over an elaborate meal of bajra rotis, *aloo subzi*, *kadhi*, rice with green gram and buttermilk – Jahabhai shows us his recent work. He pulls out a pile of neatly folded tangaliya saris in cotton silk from a steel almirah. The shades are stunning: electric



blue with hot pink stripes; a dual shade bottle green that sways between peacock blue and green, mustard and red...

He also makes running fabric, stoles and unstitched kurta suits. “It takes six months to make a sari; roughly five days to make a 1.5 metre fabric with motifs,” says Jahabhai as he gestures for us to follow him to his workshop – a single room equipped with a weaving loom. The loom requires simultaneous hand and feet movement to run, which seems complicated, but when he begins, the speed and precision make it look almost effortless.

Nevertheless, it is a painstaking process, especially when I try my hand at it. The loom has several threads attached. The weft is silk, and the warp, cotton. I am instructed to segregate three threads, then take a colour yarn and roll it around the threads till it cocoons them. This sounds easy but when I am done, I notice my work lacks symmetry, and the shape, size and finish are chaotic.

Knots and dots

In Surendranagar, Gujarat, we visit artisanal communities working with brands like Jaypore to revive the intricate craft of tangaliya for contemporary wardrobes

This village has five families that weave tangaliya fabric – a steep drop from earlier numbers of 38-40, with children of weavers moving out and taking up jobs like driving autos, working in shops or becoming watchmen. The other neighbouring villages also have a few tangaliya weavers, around 60 families in total.

“After revival efforts, in 2007 by Rajesh Gupta and Vandita Seth from Gandhinagar NIFT, things are better,” says Jahabhai, adding, “They did a few projects with us. They suggested that we incorporate different fabrics and also taught us to expand beyond saris and create cushion covers, stoles and dress materials and work on



It takes six months to make a sari; roughly five days to make a 1.5 metre fabric with motifs

JAHABHAI

weaves at great speed while chatting with us. He moves rhythmically, as if keeping up with a phantom music conductor. Ishwarbhai is working on a piece with intricate thread work that has taken him 13 months. “Five and a half metres, with elaborate work, take 15 days,” he explains. The more the motifs, the more a sari costs – anywhere from ₹7,500 to a lakh and more. We ask him if he is aware that celebrities are wearing his weaves. “I saw a video on YouTube where an actor from the South was wearing my creation. But I don’t know his name,” he grins. He is just happy to be weaving.

Does his work get challenging? “Sometimes the thread breaks or becomes weak, other than that I have no difficulties,” he smiles and adds, “I work right next to my house, I have a roof on top and a fan that keeps me comfortable. I like doing what I do. What more could I want?”

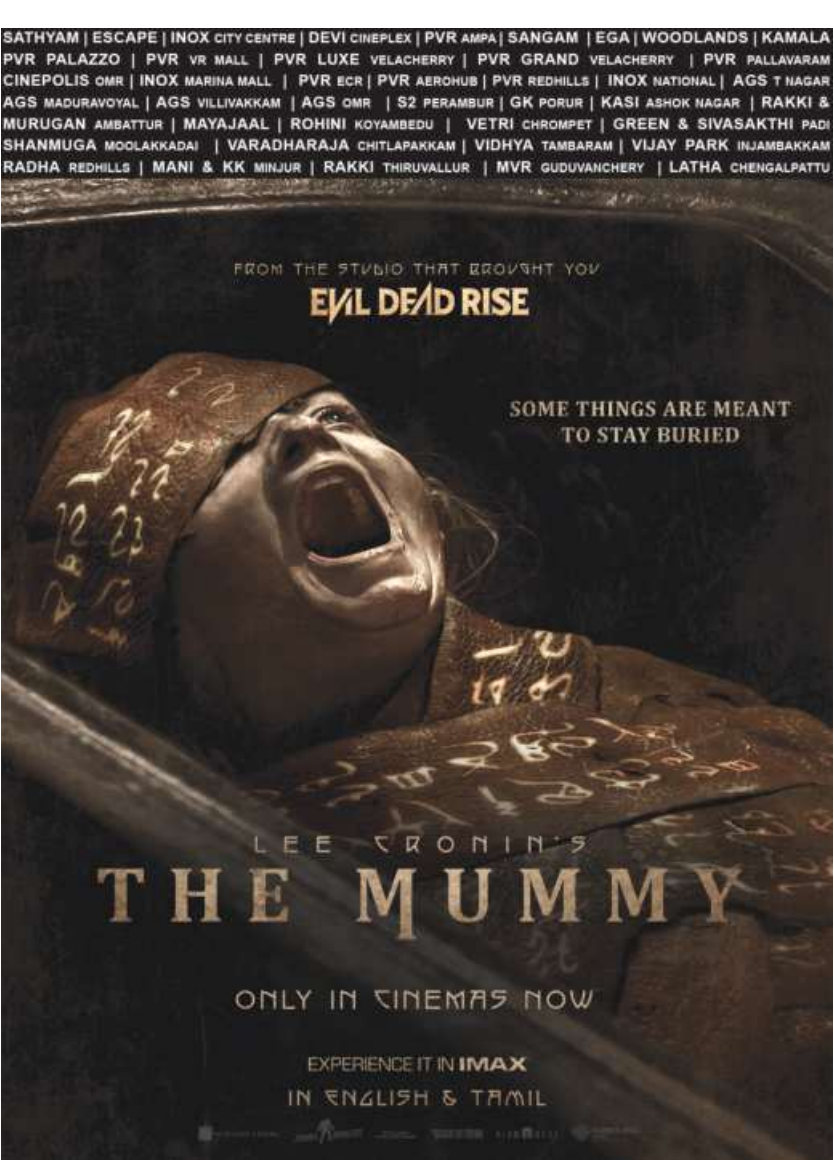
Fortunately for the craft, tangaliya is finally on the radar of designers and design houses. “We have seen encouraging interest from customers,” says Manu. It gained wider attention after Brad Pitt wore a blue tangaliya shirt in *F1* by label 11.11 that was crafted by Baldevbhai Mohanbhai Rathore. Though Jahabhai and the weavers are blissfully unaware of who Brad Pitt is, they continue to do what they do with love and respect for their craft.

The writer was in Gujarat on invitation of Jaypore



Textile tales

Forever Gara, a new coffee table book by author-designer Vanita Bhandari, celebrates the rich legacy of Parsi embroidery – one of India’s intricate textile traditions. Tracing its journey from historic trade routes between Canton and Gujarat to its place in contemporary Parsi wardrobes, the book brings together archival references, detailed visuals, and layered narratives. It also reflects Vanita’s personal engagement with the craft through her label Pegara, alongside her mother Pervaz Aggarwal. Forever Gara is both a visual archive and a tribute to heirloom textiles that carry stories across generations. Extending beyond documentation, the book captures a living craft that continues to evolve in modern contexts. Through Pegara, traditional gara motifs are reimagined across contemporary silhouettes, making the craft relevant to a wider audience. Each piece requiring months of handwork, the practice highlights slow fashion and sustained craftsmanship. Priced ₹6999, the book is available at the Pegara store, Carmichael Road, Mumbai. To order call: 9819614701.





Named in *TIME's 100*, Vikas Khanna turns away from expansion to create Bungalow in New York — a restaurant that will last just ten years

Spiced with soul

Rini Chatterjee

From New York's East Village to the wider world, Chef Vikas Khanna has turned Bungalow into more than a restaurant: a place that carries memory, identity, and storytelling in every plate. Fresh off being named in *TIME's 2026 TIME100*, where he appears under the Innovators category — which recognises individuals who are reshaping industries and ideas — the Amritsar-born chef stands as one of the most visible Indian culinary voices on the global stage today. His 2026 James Beard Award semifinalist nod for Best Chef: New York State underlines how fully American culinary institutions have taken note of what he has built.

You descend into Bungalow,

past pale pink walls and carved wooden panels, past a bookshelf lined with Indian cookbooks in Bengali, Gujarati and Marathi, past a framed photograph of the chef's mother on her wedding day, and something shifts. The noise of Manhattan fades. The air thickens with the fragrance of fresh flowers arranged, every single day, in the shape of Ganesh on a glass-covered ceiling. The room smells the way a living temple does: of devotion, turmeric, and of someone who cares deeply about the space you are about to enter.

A promise kept
Bungalow opened on March 23, 2024, the date that would have been the 50th birthday of Vikas's beloved late sister, Radhika, a fashion designer who passed away in 2022. The restaurant is his answer to that loss, part memorial, part manifesto. He has given it a

deadline: 10 years, and then the doors close. "After Junoon, I wasn't planning on opening another restaurant," he said. "The five years of trying to save my sister, my best friend and my twin, it killed me. This was her dream and I am just keeping my promise to her."

In an industry that rewards volume, more seats, more cities, more social media noise, Vikas has chosen restraint. Three hundred dinners a night for 10 years, and then a dignified departure. It is an unusual position for a man with a staggering number of Michelin stars on

(Clockwise from top left) Interiors of Bungalow, dishes at Bungalow; Chef Vikas Khanna. ELSYIA BY SWAPNIL

his résumé, a *MasterChef India* judgeship across seven seasons, over 40 published books, a film screened at Cannes, and a celebrity guest list featuring Shah Rukh Khan, Mukesh Ambani, Priyanka Chopra Jonas, Sarah Jessica Parker among others. New York in 2026 is not the New York of the curry house era. The landscape of expectation has shifted in visible stages: the 1970s through the 1990s, when Indian food was "ethnic", a question of quantity and comfort; the 2000s, when fine dining began to flirt with Indian ingredients, mostly as accent or novelty; the 2010s, when a clearer idea emerged that Indian cuisine could be technique-driven, wine-paired, Michelin-level. For decades, the West wanted "General Indian" because it was safe: butter chicken, tikka masala, naan, a familiar playlist of flavours. It was comfort food without context. But the modern diner is evolving. They want truth. They are tired of generic experiences.

Regional specificity, Tamil, Odia, Konkani, Khasi, Malvani, Awadhi, Kashmiri, offers something the monolith never could: identity with edges. Chef Vikas adds that 2025 James Beard Award winner Chef Vijay Kumar's strength lies in serving authentic village food that is seasonal, hyper-local, and built entirely from scratch at Semma in New York, proving that what was once "unmarketable" becomes desirable when the world finally values integrity over imitation.

Some of the most moving moments at Bungalow are not the loud ones. It is when a guest quietly says, "This tastes like my mother," and then

pauses, because they surprised themselves. Food does not just feed. It unlocks old doors. And then there is this: a non-Indian guest takes a bite and becomes suddenly still. The flavour is unfamiliar, but it feels precise. That stillness is respect. That is the moment when you know you did not have to

dilute anything.

Everything Vikas does comes back to the way he was raised, where feeding someone was not a transaction but a duty of love. A home where doors locked only after everyone was safe. Where the last thing you did at night was check if someone had eaten.

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Malayalam

A rationalist bent to its dark humour



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A dead body in the house can be one of the most horrific situations or a source of mirth, depending on the tone and treatment that a movie adopts. *Mohiniyattam*, which gently spoofs *Drishyam*, turns the situation into a hilarious affair, with periodic reminders of the dead man's deceitful nature, supposedly to make us laugh without any sense of guilt.

Sequels often end up as pale imitations of the original. But in conceiving a sequel to the mildly funny *Bharathanatyam* (which incidentally was a spoof of *Balettan*), Krishnadas Murali reimagines the original's basic theme, injecting it with loads of dark humour and turning it into a markedly better film, like *Vaazha 2* last week.

Sasidharan (Saiju Kurup), the protagonist, still holds some of the weight of the secret his father Bharathan had revealed about him having another family. The gags surrounding the two "almost" identical twins also get referred to a few times.

But the narrative takes a new turn, portraying a shady, money-making scheme run by his father and friends for quite some time. This idea is perhaps the strongest element of the film, with a few sharp, satirical jibes at the origin of some irrational religious practices.

The animated origin story is unimaginable in present-day Bollywood, where such rational questions don't find a place now. The two families of Bharathan are one large team, working together seamlessly whenever an adversity strikes, most evident in the long sequence where an unwelcome guest wreaks havoc in their home.

Murali and co-writer Vishnu R. Pradeep present a few parallel scenarios, but the thread about getting rid of the dead body becomes tiresome. The entry of the two 'Subhashs' (rapper Baby Jean and Abhiram Radhakrishnan) with their crooked brains working at cross purposes, somewhat enlivens the proceedings. The sagging narrative suddenly comes to life and ends on a high.

Apart from Saiju Kurup, the one who draws the most laughs is Kalaranjini, who has quite a ball adding an element of quirkiness to the original character. Amid a host of characters indulging in zany acts, she steals the scene with her gestures, which lifts one of the key scenes in the movie. Electronic Kili's music offers a different mood to the film.

With a rationalist bent to its dark humour, *Mohiniyattam* is several notches above the original film.

Mohiniyattam is currently running in theatres



This futuristic rom-com loses its edge

In a neon-drenched Chennai of 2040, Vignesh Shivan crafts an imaginative rom-com that charms in parts but struggles to sustain its ideas

Tamil

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You are presented with an irresistible offer that could change your life altogether – an AI-powered mobile application learns everything about you to help not only find love but also 'protect' the relationship through surveillance and a system of credits. The alternative is to follow your instincts, trust your heart, embrace people with their imperfections, and hope everything works out for the best – basically, like how humans have always survived. Which option would you take?

In an age where dating apps and social media platforms have become the primary avenues for meeting people, the possibility of such an app is very real. In his latest film, *Love Insurance Kompany*, writer-director Vignesh Shivan attempts to show the perils of such extreme dependence on technology and that no robot can fully understand the wonders of the human heart.

To show this, he constructs a futuristic megalopolis where technological advancements dictate how humans should lead their lives. Vignesh Shivan's Chennai of 2040 is a neon-drenched technopolis with holographic signboards on towering skyscrapers, exquisite public spaces, and state-of-the-art mobile and mobility innovations. The Rajiv Gandhi Government Hospital, for instance, is a high-tech utopian medical centre with air ambulances. Robots and mobile applications are so entwined with human lives that you can even get a drone to deliver condoms to your door – and everyone is addicted to the alluring escape that smartphones provide. Ruling this world is Love Insurance Kompany (LIK), a next-generation social-media-cum-dating-app founded by Suriyan (SJ Suryah). The app lets users connect, track their relationship status, and offers tips and advice, and even surveils them with a wearable ring. The voice of LIK is provided by a young

Love Insurance Kompany

Director: Vignesh Shivan

Cast: Pradeep Ranganathan, Krithi Shetty, SJ Suryah, Seeman

Storyline: In a futuristic Chennai, a carefree young man falls in love with a woman devoted to an all-powerful dating app, setting him on a path to challenge the very system that governs love and relationships.



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man named Vaibhav Vasudevan a.k.a. Vibe Vassey (Pradeep Ranganathan), a youngster who lives a carefree life since he doesn't even own a mobile phone. Vassey is the son of Anbukadal (Seeman), a man who runs a safe commune called Organic World, which is essentially a rehab for cyber criminals and those suffering from nomophobia. Everything changes for Vassey when he bumps into a beauty named Dheema (Krithi Shetty); his heart skips a beat, literally, and Vassey falls in love. We soon realise that Dheema is a popular vlogger and influencer, who, owing to her single mother's avoidant relationship, grew up with the comforts of smartphones and social media. Dheema places her complete trust in LIK to find her soulmate, while Vassey shares his father's disbelief in gadgets. Does Vassey get his lady love? What happens when Suriyan's LIK plays spoilsport in Vassey's romantic quest?

Right off the bat, Vignesh sells the many pleasures of seeing a futuristic Chennai with easy conviction. You casually come across a poster of *Thalaivar 189* and *Mission Impossible 14*; Indian economy has grown to such an extent that an unemployed American can be seen selling umbrellas on Chennai streets; and there's a Hollywood sign-inspired Kollywood monument on St Thomas Mount. What might irk one, though, is how the camera constantly seems to be in a rush, never quite pausing on one of these futuristic details.

It's nice to see Vignesh in his element. This is a filmmaker who believes in saccharine, fantastical ideas of romance – like love-at-first-sight and grand gestures. In *LIK*, Vassey suffers from a heart attack – literally – when he first meets Dheema. Even typing that should have induced cringe, but believe me when I say that Vignesh sells the idea with terrible ease. The meet-cute is staged with an old-school charm, painting the leads in angelic glow, and one cannot help but smile knowing that there exists a filmmaker who had the conviction that this would work in 2026. Shortly after Vassey is admitted to a hospital, we are introduced to the core theme of the film – that finding your soulmate is in the hands of the universe, and not depended on an app.

LIK has a harmless set-up that's quite simple for its own good. The colourful backdrops and eccentric characters all keep you in splendid company; however, the film sadly suffers from the post-intermission blues that seem to have struck Tamil cinema of late. The film sees an apparent dip post-interval and *LIK* quickly loses its rhythm. Vignesh has always shown an affinity for taking on challenging topics. In his previous film, *Kaathuvaakula Rendu Kaadhal*, the director attempted to explore the conundrum of a man in love with two women at the same time, and, like in that case, here too, the director struggles to delve deeper as he merely offers a superficial commentary.

There's also a visible struggle to find ways to wrap it all up. A fight sequence is a trite resolution tactic, and it's sad to know that even in a film set in 2040, we still get grand exposés to the public as a pre-climax. The whole characterisation of Suriyan stands on unstable grounds as we never quite understand what had driven him to despise humans so much. Vignesh seems to have missed a cue to offer Suriyan a credible backstory, something that interestingly helps Anbukadal, who is on the opposing side of the spectrum.

What keeps the film going through such rough patches are the vivid frames of Ravi Varman, an excellent score by Anirudh Ravichander, and the able performances of the lead stars. While SJ Suryah does what he does best, Pradeep once again impresses with his many Gen Z-coded mannerisms and body language. Krithi Shetty, on the other hand, surprises with her performance.

In the midst of everything happening in *LIK*, there's a love story of a man who had been in an accident, which is shown from two distinct perspectives to question the idea that personal surveillance could help solve infidelity. An arc around an ice cream seller questions the idea of love that is generally considered acceptable. Such writing is the strong suit of Vignesh Shivan, who, despite failing to finish his film on a high note, delivers a simple, entertaining and casual rom-com that feels human.

Love Insurance Kompany is currently running in theatres

A simmering old-school romance

Telugu

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Dacoit: A Love Story keeps its biggest surprises under wraps, even as its team amped up pre-release promotions. Directed by Shaneil Deo and led by Adivi Sesh and Mrunal Thakur, the Telugu-Hindi bilingual is, at its heart, an emotional love story with an Indian ethos, told through a Western lens. The emphasis on "at its heart" is deliberate – embedded within is a distinctly old-school romance that nods to cinematic tropes of the past, hoping to resonate with a swipe-era audience.

For that to land, the writing of both characters and subplots needs to hold. Sesh and Shaneil, who share screenplay credits, pack the film with layered, often complex characters. Threads of possible deceit and double-crossing keep the narrative engaging at key moments. While a few characters verge on being



one-note, the complexity of the central figures ultimately works in the film's favour.

When the film reveals all its cards towards the end, some of the early lines in the love story, initially seeming routine, acquire new meaning. Screenplay supervisor Abburi Ravi, who also writes the Telugu dialogues, revisits certain lines through the film, allowing them to gather emotional weight as the narrative unfolds.

More than the thin plot, it is the

non-linear storytelling that lends *Dacoit* its intrigue. The 152-minute film wastes little time, building momentum from the opening credits. The whirl of windmills across the Andhra-Karnataka border, captured in ultra-wide frames by cinematographer Danush Bhaskar, contrasts sharply with the gloom of a prison cell where Hari Das (Adivi Sesh) is introduced. The camera lingers on his 'J' tattoo – a nod to his Juliet, Saraswathy (Mrunal Thakur) – as he holds back tears. What follows

establishes Hari's duality: irreverent in public, yet vulnerable in solitude or among those he trusts.

Set in 2021, in the aftermath of the second lockdown, the narrative travels back to 2005. The sun-scorched landscape becomes a character in itself. The film interweaves Hari and Saraswathy's love-hate dynamic with action. A standout sequence places heat, dust, trains and guns against a remix of the popular song 'Kannepettaru' from *Hello Brother*, starring Nagarjuna Akkineni. Crucially, the sequence avoids glorification of the hero; it subtly underscores that while Hari may have toughened in prison, he is no hardened criminal. That vulnerability makes him believable.

When the story shifts to an unlikely partnership between Hari and Saraswathy, attempting a series of heists, it is this vulnerability that draws the audience in. They are novices – fumbling, improvising, racing against time. The amateurish quality of some heists is intentional. Alongside their personal struggles, a subplot on pandemic-era medical exploitation – black fungus,

Remdesivir, and mounting hospital bills – adds emotional heft, evoking a collective memory many would rather forget.

The film's social commentary, particularly its undercurrent of caste hierarchies, adds further layers. Even the names, Hari and Saraswathy, alongside their nicknames Romeo and Juliet, feed into this discourse.

However, after building strong momentum, the film falters in its later stretches. The heist sequences begin to overstay their welcome, and some key revelations feel

predictable. It is not difficult to anticipate why someone gets framed. It is also not tough to connect the dots when a child appears on screen.

Yet, the caste discourse lands effectively. When a character questions why some escape consequences, the film resists easy answers.

At its core, the film rests on Mrunal and Sesh. This marks another strong addition to Mrunal's Telugu filmography. As the emotional anchor, she delivers a nuanced performance, elevated further by Chinmayi Sripada's dubbing. For Sesh, known for his tightly written thrillers, this film tests his acting range, and he rises to the occasion. His dialect, thought, is uneven.

Dacoit is not an easy film to instantly celebrate or dismiss. Its old-school approach to romance is a bold choice. Does it fully land? Not quite. With tighter action and fewer predictable turns, it could have been a sure-shot winner.

Dacoit is currently running in theatres

Shrinking

Creators: Bill Lawrence, Jason Segel, Brett Goldstein

Starring: Jason Segel, Jessica Williams, Luke Tennie, Michael Urie, Lukita Maxwell, Christa Miller, Harrison Ford, Ted McGinley

Storyline: There are major changes in Jimmy's life, as well as in the lives of those around him



Growing pains, gentle goodbyes

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

The multiple-award winning *Shrinking* continues to charm its way into our lives, with laughter, tears, and therapy. Jimmy (Jason Segel), the therapist coming to terms with the grief of losing his wife, Tia (Lilan Bowden), faces big changes in his life.

His daughter, Alice (Lukita Maxwell) is leaving for college. War vet Sean (Luke Tennie), who was Jimmy's patient, and

is living in Jimmy's pool house, has been doing well with his food truck. An offer and a reconnection with his ex-girlfriend, Marisol (Isabella Gomez), make him realise it is time for him to move on.

Gaby (Jessica Williams), Jimmy's colleague, sees a chance for her dream of setting up a trauma centre to come true but does not know if she is ready for it. She is also not sure if she wants to take the next step with her boyfriend, Derrick (Damon Wayans Jr.). A new patient, Maya (Sherry Cola), makes Gaby question her methods.

Paul (Harrison Ford), Jimmy's mentor and senior therapist at the centre, has to take a call on professional and personal matters as his Parkinson's disease worsens. His daughter, Meg (Lily Rabe), would like him to move closer to her in Connecticut. The one-hour season opener sees Paul marry his neurologist girlfriend Julie (Wendie Malick).

Jimmy's neighbours, Liz (Christa Miller) and Derek (Ted McGinley) re-evaluate their lives after Derek has a health

scare. Jimmy's best friend and lawyer, Brian (Michael Urie), and his husband Charlie (Devin Kawaoka), are enjoying being parents to Sutton, the baby they are bringing up together, with lots of help from Liz. When Charlie has to move to Tennessee for three months, Brian has to decide whether to join him there.

Shrinking follows all these arcs with a light touch and the ensemble cast keeps us invested in the stories. Whether it is Jimmy finally taking the plunge into the dating life with Sofi (Cobie Smulders), Liz and Derek showing some tough love to their son Matthew (Markus Silbiger) or Louis (Brett Goldstein), the drunk driver responsible for Tia's death, finally being able to forgive himself and return to his graphic design roots.

The guest stars in *Shrinking* do some heavy lifting as well. Michael J. Fox's appearance as Jerry, a Parkinson's patient Paul meets at the doctor's office, is deeply affecting without being showy, and he gives Paul a mantra to live by.

With its assured balancing

act between laughter, tears, anger, grief, warmth and wit, *Shrinking* delivers the complete package. We also learn of Paul's childhood and his early years as a therapist.

There are so many nuggets of wisdom that you immediately want to try out and the fact that none of it is heavy-handed is a major plus for the series.

Shrinking was originally conceived as a three-season arc according to one of the creators, Bill Lawrence. With the series being renewed for a fourth season, Lawrence has said there will be a new storyline with the same characters.

The finale of Season 3 closes the arc for all the characters delightfully and even if there is no fourth season, it would have been a perfect ending. That is not to say we do not wish to see further adventures of the therapists and their friends at the Cognitive Behavioral Therapy Center.

Shrinking is currently streaming on Apple TV+

Snippets



Rapper King to make acting debut with action series Lukkhe

Rapper and songwriter King will be making his acting debut with Prime Video's upcoming musical action series Lukkhe. Directed by Himank Gaur, the show also stars Raashii Khanna, Palak Tiwari, Lakshvir Singh Saran, Nakul Roshan Sahdev, and Ayesha Raza Mishra in pivotal roles. The show is set in Chandigarh and follows an intersection of rap, crime and culture. Speaking about the show, creator and executive producers of the series Agrim Joshi and Debojit Das Purkayastha said in a statement, "*Lukkhe* has been a true passion project for us" Produced by Vipul D Shah and Rajesh Bahl, the series will be released on Prime Video on May 8.



Ayushmann Khurrana and Sara Ali Khan to star in spy comedy

Ayushmann Khurrana and Sara Ali Khan will be seen next in the spy-comedy *Udda Teer*. The film is backed by Dharma Productions and Sikhya Entertainment, marking their fourth collaboration after *Kill*, *Gyaarah Gyaarah*, and *The Lunchbox*. The film has been written and directed by Akash A Kaushik in his directorial debut. It is produced by Karan Johar, Adar Poonawalla, Apoorva Mehta, Guneet Monga Kapoor, and Achin Jain and will be released in theatres on September 11, 2026. More details from the film are awaited.



'Saiyaara' director Mohit Suri reunites with Ahaan Panday and Aneet Padda

After the smashing success of *Saiyaara*, director Mohit Suri will be reuniting with breakout actors Ahaan Panday and Aneet Padda for another intense romance that remains currently untitled. The film will be backed by Yash Raj Films and will be a blend of "heartfelt storytelling with unforgettable melodies", as per a press release. It is set to go on floors later this year and will be eyeing a 2027 theatrical release. *Saiyaara* was released on July 18 last year and turned out to be a breakout hit.



The pathology of a bully

Vinay Pathak's brutal turn exposes the toxicity of dysfunctional relationships cloaked in civility in this Rajat Kapoor whodunit

Hindi

Anuj Kumar

Quietly subversive and more interested in human frailty than genre payoffs, *Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa* is a quintessential Rajat Kapoor film. It doesn't reinvent the whodunit, but it humanises it, turning a murder mystery into a mirror held up to the insidious violence we inflict on the people we claim to love. The final reveal and tonal balance don't fully satisfy, but it is a respectable experiment that fiercely tugs at the deepest strings of the heart.

To celebrate their 10th wedding anniversary, Raman (Neil Bhoopalam) and Jayanti (Palomi Ghosh) invite a close group of friends and family for an intimate getaway at a sprawling century-old mansion in the hills. Among the guests is Raman's business partner, Sohrab Handa (Vinay Pathak), a sharp-tongued, unapologetically abrasive presence who dominates every conversation with his acid wit and honesty. Sohrab is perceptive, knowing which insecurities to poke and how to cloak them in humour.

What starts as a night of laughter, drinking, games, and nostalgia quickly turns sour as old resentments, hidden

Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa

Director: Rajat Kapoor

Cast: Vinay Pathak, Ranvir Shorey, Rajat Kapoor, Saurabh Shukla, Neil Bhoopalam, Danish Husain, Chandrachoor Rai, Koel Purie, Sadiya Siddiqui, Waluscha De Souza, Palomi Ghosh, M.K. Raina

Synopsis: At a lavish party, the foul-mouthed and universally loved Sohrab Handa is found dead, forcing his friends and family to confront the toxic truths they've tolerated for years.

grudges, and interpersonal tensions bubble to the surface. Late at night, Sohrab is found dead with his throat slit in the hall.

Knives are out as Handa's death shatters the facade of performative civility. In comes the sleep-deprived, straightforward inspector Afzal Qureshi (Saurabh Shukla). Suddenly, the celebration becomes a pressure-cooker investigation, with everyone present potentially having a motive. If Handa is brutal, there is Madhavan (Ranvir Shorey), a gentle philosophy professor with his young, besotted student, and Chandra (Rajat), a perceptive psychologist. The two gradually reveal the masks worn by society and individuals. As secrets unravel and friendships fracture under suspicion, Kapoor explores the irony of the title – how love can coexist with deep loathing in close relationships. When a bully is celebrated or tolerated, does that behavior become contagious? The film has been waiting in the wings for a while, but Kapoor's probing gaze feels even more timely now.

The form is familiar, but the matter and moments probe the human psyche. Much like Govind Nihalani's *Party*, the crux of the conversation is to dissect urban social circles to highlight the hypocrisies we live with. It is rooted in a witty dialogue emanating from uncomfortable truths between a journalist (Danish Husain), who sees news as a commodity, Prof Madhavan, who feels we have failed as a society and admits that people like him

opted out to join easier options, and, of course, Handa, who feels the intellectuals add a cipher to the economy. It is the businessman who generates wealth and employment.

The thoughtfully cast ensemble keeps the party alive and uncomfortably real. Vinay, Ranvir, and Rajat go back a long way. Like frenemies, they know how to push each other's buttons over a glass of wine. It is good to see veteran M.K. Raina cast in a role beyond just a genial uncle. Koel Purie is efficient as the long-suffering wife of Handa, whose unpredictable behaviour makes her a suspect. The seasoned Sadiya Siddiqui retains her freshness as the everyday woman interested in a moment of freedom from the humdrum rather than in the intricate designs of those around her.

Riding on Rafeeq Mahmood's fluid camera, Resul Pukotty's atmospheric sound design, and an understated background score by Sagar Desai, the narrative moves briskly, capturing different perspectives and maintaining an unsettling yet playful tone. Having said that, Kapoor seems a little too devoted to the psychological exploration of the theme, and he loses grip on the mystery aspect in the second half, with threads hanging loose. But then, Kapoor is not known for conjuring something that everybody loves.

Everybody Loves Sohrab Handa is currently streaming on ZEE5